FCI was moving about 1.93 metric tonnes of food grains, a significant increase from even pre-lockdown levels.

On further observation, it was noted that most of the outgoing movement was occurring in Punjab, Haryana, Telangana, Chhattisgarh, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. Induction markers showed that maximum consumption movement was in Uttar Pradesh followed by Bihar, West Bengal and Karnataka. These were also strong indicators that there was a definite increase in the delivery of food grains as promised under the PMGKAY scheme, from the early days of the lockdown. Adding an anecdote, a close aide of the prime minister noted that, 'The PM drew several inferences from studying previous pandemics which led him to believe that food security and an unhindered agricultural sector were what would see the country through the pandemic years. That is when he decided to formulate the PMGKAY. Even after the countrywide lockdown he directed us to ensure that the agricultural sector functioned smoothly and that all their roadblocks were solved on priority as the aforementioned example.'

In the Indian bureaucratic system, typically, procurement and specifically procurement of high-value items is a very tedious and slow process, encompassing several levels of officers across varying levels of authority. This kind of tendering is usually done to keep a check on corruption and leave out favouritism amongst vendors. Owing to this system, officers often hesitate to make quick decisions on procurement, fearing that they would come under the line of fire for impulsive purchases. However, in the COVID-19 crisis, it was imperative that the officers felt comfortable enough to purchase necessary items in high quantities quickly. To enable this, on 27 March, the Finance Ministry released an order providing necessary relaxations and issuing suitable guidelines for specific ministries namely Department of Pharmaceuticals, MoHFW, Ministry of Textiles, Department of Consumer Affairs and Ministry of Civil Aviation.[40] The order further read,

> The prevailing health emergency requires immediate procurement of certain items in quantities which may not be available with a single supplier and/or within the time frame in which they are needed. There is also a possibility that some items may not be available in the country in sufficient quantity within the time frame in which they are needed. Certain items and equipment are currently